



ShabbaTTogether

Dvar Torah/Class - Mental Health

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Goals:

- Destigmatizing mental health conditions
- Creating a sense of communal responsibility towards each other
- Creating an environment of support and belonging
- Teaching Chassidus as a foundation for self-worth and mental wellness

Target Audience:

Adults

Time:

Approximately 30-45 minutes

Medium:

Facilitated Program. Virtual or In-person.

Note to Facilitator:

This Dvar begins with a buildup of themes and questions that will be brought together at the end. However, it was created in a way that you can pick and leave whichever parts are meaningful to you, and use the bullet points to further these ideas in your own words. There are **ideas on Adar, Purim, and 2 Parsha options from Chassidus or Rabbi Sacks Z"l**. You can use one or both. Alternatively, you can use the sources provided as a Pre-Shabbos class.

Welcome

Shabbat Shalom! Welcome to ShabbaTTogether - an incredible global initiative highlighting Disability Inclusion and Mental Health and Wellness in our community and communities around the world.

Pandemic - Together Yet Isolated

- In light of the current Pandemic, this initiative seems more important than ever.
- We are all affected in some way. As it has been said - "We are all in the same storm, but each one of us has a unique boat."
- Whether we are consumed by health or financial concerns, mourning a loss, or feeling the effects of isolation, changed plans, or the constant unknown looming over us, everyone has a story. **Most of those stories are hidden from view, behind a veiled curtain.**
- According to a recent study in the UK, vulnerable groups (who already have mental health conditions) were experiencing almost double the amount of health anxiety, increased depression and general anxiety than the general population. However, the intolerance of being able to deal with the uncertainty is not necessarily more in any particular group. (Rettie & Daniels 2020)
- **Collectively we know we are all in this together, yet in many of our struggles we grieve alone.**

Rosh Chodesh Adar

- In the midst of the painful state we find ourselves, tonight [this weekend] is also Rosh Chodesh Adar - the new month of Adar. This means that one of the most joyous Jewish celebrations, Purim, is around the corner!
- We extol the bravery and faith of our heroine Queen Esther and Jewish leader Mordechai (We will return to this shortly).

Optional: The Moon cycle

- We celebrate the new Jewish month by the cycle of the moon- if you look outside you will notice just a tiny slither in the sky.
- G-d showed Moses the moon in its renewal and said, "When the moon is renewed, that will be the head of the month." (Rashi's Commentary, Exodus 12:2)
- As Jews, there is a profound message hidden within the beginning of each month. The reflected light of the moon waxes and wanes. It fluctuates from it's full glory, to darkness, and slowly shines it's light once more.
- We celebrate a new month right after the moon experiences it's darkest phase, and a small slither of light emerges once again.
- As a nation, we are no strangers to the cycle of struggle and loss , and ultimately of rebuilding and renewal.
- **We celebrate our ability to somehow move forward with our pain, and once again shine a little light. It celebrates our faith that we trust that our story will not end in darkness. Once again, light will emerge.**

Adar's transformation

- This message is even more profound in the new month of Adar that we celebrate tonight.
- According to Jewish mysticism every Jewish month has a new energy we can tap into and actualise/manifest in our own personal life.
- In fact, the hebrew word for Chodesh- month, is also connected to the word Chadash- new- a new energy we can tap in to.
- Purim, the holiday of Adar, commemorates the “metamorphosis” of the Jews’ apparent bad fortune (as it appeared to Haman) to good. We celebrate the transformation from darkness to light.
- Hindsight allows us to see how the gift of having a Jewish Queen in the palace allowed for a dangerous yet diplomatic transformation of a catastrophe for the Jews into a celebration.
- The Megillah itself says: **The month that was reversed for them from grief to joy.** (Esther 9:22)
- (Optional- The word Adar can be broken into A/Dar -the Hebrew letter ‘alef’ representing the oneness of G-d ‘dar’ – dwells. By recognising the constant and continuous presence and loving Guidance of G-d in our lives, we can become aware of the light that comes from darkness–“the advantage of light from darkness”–as is the case with regard to the miracle of Purim. The Jewish people’s faith in G-d, led by Mordechai and Esther, revealed the light in the darkest of times.)
- Hence the Talmud highlights the unique energy of Adar: (Taanit 29a) **“When the month of Adar enters, we increase joy.”**
- The word Adar is also connected to the Hebrew word for “strength” (אֲדִיר). Adar is the month of good fortune for the Jewish people. The sages say of Adar: “Its mazal [fortune] is strong.”

The Question

- **But how can we tap into a month of joy, when we feel furthest from it? How can we help someone else find a drop of joy this month?**
- Let’s dive into Esther’s narrative and some profound insights from this week’s Torah portion that can help us shed light on our own struggles, on the importance of Mental Health Awareness, reducing stigma, the meaning of true inclusion, and ultimately increasing just a little bit more joy.

Queen Esther’s lonely struggle

- In hindsight, the Purim miracle can seem clear and smooth. Like all Jewish Holidays: they tried to kill us, we won, let's eat!
- But even just a simple reading of the Megillah reveals that **the process for the characters, our heroes and heroines, was full of uncertainty, pain and darkness.**
- Let's take down the veil on Esther for a moment.
- When we meet her it seems like she has it all:
 - (Esther 2:18)“Esther was taken to the King Ahasuerus into his palace. The king loved Esther more than all the women, and she won more of his grace and favor

than all the other girls; so that he set the royal crown upon her head, and made her queen in place of Vashti."

- **If we saw her on social media, we would all be scrolling through reels of magnificent palace rooms, jewels and flawless beauty. Yet...**
- (From an article by Elana mizrahi via chabad.org) "Esther, Queen Esther, from the outside looks like she has it so easy. She has beauty, grace, incredible wealth and such power! She's the queen!..(yet) No one knows Esther's background, what nation she belongs to, nor her religion. Does anyone, except for her cousin Mordechai, know her suffering? Do they know that she's being held against her will? Do they understand that she's lonely, isolated from her people, forced to observe her religion in hiding?"
- **If we were privy to life behind the mask- would we know the pain she endures daily in isolation?**
- From here we can already learn the **power of awareness**: A recognition that you have no idea what someones personal struggle is. "Everyone you meet is fighting a battle you know nothing about. Be kind. Always."(author unknown)

Question broadens:

- **Yet what insight can the Purim story Torah give us in taking our best step forward in being there for each other in the personal and often private battles we are all facing?**
- Let's dive into this week's Torah portion for some moving insight and then we will return back to Queen Esther.

Parshat Mishpatim:

Optional: Parsha Context:

The Sacredness of Our Social Responsibilities:

- Just last week in Parshat Yitro, we heard the 10 commandments at Mount Sinai. Engraved on each side of the tablets, and imprinted in our collective Jewish consciousness is the 5 commandments regarding our responsibilities to G-d "I am the Lord your G-d... you shall not serve any other..ect) and 5 commandments outlining our responsibility to one another (You shall not be jealous/ murder/ steal ect.)
- From the outside it appears they are 2 distinct themes, but in reality they are intrinsically connected. As a Jew we have both personal and spiritual responsibilities to G-d and our fellow man. (We will explore this more shortly).
- To G-d these are one and the same. When we are kind to our fellow, we show respect to the image of G-d within every human being. As well as being commanded about uniquely Jewish mitzvot, customs and rituals, the civil and social laws in Judaism are just as sacred. Whether we would have done it on our own in a just society, they are still uniquely Jewish mitzvot.
- Similarly, this week's Torah portion continues with our collective social responsibility to one another:
- (Exodus 21:1:)"*And these are the laws which you shall set before them.*"
- Rashi Highlights: "*The phrase "and these" (ve'eileh hamishpatim) implies that they are a continuation of what is written before. This is to teach us that just as the laws written*

above (the Ten Commandments) are from Sinai, these too are from Sinai" (Mechilta; Rashi).

- In this sense, **Rashi is highlighting the sacredness of our social responsibility as a continuation of the Sinai revelation and inseparable from our purpose and mission as a people.**

Mishpatim Themes

- Mishpatim contains some of the most profound and fundamental social legislation in the Torah.
- It contains 53 Mitzvot: 23 commandments and 30 prohibitions.
- These include:
 - prohibitions against harassing/taking advantage of a foreigner, widow, or orphan; bribery, injustice, and judicial corruption
 - the mitzvah of lending money to the poor and the prohibition against lending with interest
 - the penalties for murder, kidnapping, assault and theft
 - civil laws pertaining to redress of damages including for personal injury and property damage

A powerful mitzvah: Unloading the Burden

- Let's zoom into one seemingly peculiar mitzvah of **social responsibility**, which seems to really extend beyond basic common sense:
- *"If you see the donkey of your enemy collapsing under its burden, and are inclined to desist from helping him, you shall surely help along with him."* (23:5)
- This mitzvah seems to go beyond our default inclination! My family or best friend that I love, I am ready to help...
- But here, The Torah is demanding us to stop even for our ENEMY'S donkey who is struggling.
- In our society, we tend to want to "live and let live." I'll figure my stuff out, and let them deal with theirs.
- Let's explore this through the lense of Jewish mysticism to shed light on the importance of Mental Health Awareness, and how we can be empowered to help each other.

Spiritual Dimension of the Mitzvah:

- Jewish Mysticism teaches that every law has a “body”- the practical and legal application, as well as the “soul” - the deeper spiritual significance that is relevant personally even outside the boundaries of the specific circumstance/law.
- A ritualistic mitzvah can teach us how to behave towards ourselves and our fellow, and a social/civil mitzvah can have much deeper, spiritual and personal meanings.
- Each mitzvah is a message about our inner life, and our purpose in the world embedded within each mitzvah. (Idea based on explanation by Yanki Tauber, The Inside Story, Mishpatim)

Let's make it real:

- You may not have an enemy, but most of us know that we have much less of an interest in people we don't particularly like.
- Even more than that, **sometimes this actually includes the people we LOVE. Living in close quarters during this pandemic with a roommate, sibling or parent can sometimes make it hard to just simply LIKE the people we love!**
- It's as if **it's easier to feel compassion for a stranger** or someone you don't know well who you see on Facebook or struggling on the subway, and yet it's harder to give that same compassion to the people in our lives that we live with and really love.
- The Torah recognises how easy it is to be “inclined to desist from helping him”
- Yet - “you shall surely help along with him.”
- *“Kol Yisrael Arevin Zeh la Zeh” - Every Jew is **Responsible for one another** (Rosh hashanah 29a).*

Optional: Chassidic Dimension

Chassidic teaching takes it to a whole new dimension.

(The following lesson is only loosely based on Chassidus from the Parsha. See “bringing it back to practical” for a practical message from the Talmud. However, making this first point can be very important in discussing the important issues about Mental Wellness from a Torah perspective.)

- According to the founder of the Chassidic Movement, the Baal Shem Tov, The Hebrew for **“donkey,” chamor, also means “material.”** Thus, this verse also instructs us how to perceive and relate to our own and other's physicality. **Perhaps we can relate this to how we perceive our own and others physical, material and even mental and emotional struggles.**
- According to our ancient Jewish teachings, as elaborated in the Tanya, Each of us have 2 souls- an animal soul and G-dly soul.
- Simply- this means we have two forces within us:
 - One- A G-dly soul that is our source of **constant, unwavering, inherent worth** by virtue of it being a literal piece of G-dliness, sourced in One G-d and connected to every living soul. “A Literal piece of G-d within.” (Iyov 31: 2)

- Two- We also have an animal soul- not diabolic- just the part of us looking for survival, and trying to get our needs met. This also serves as the source of our unique temperaments, our ego states, and ultimately our disparity from one another.
- We all have that **animal soul in us that just wants to get through the day.**

Buckling Under our Own load

- We all have times that **our own “donkey” within, our material and psychological self that is buckling under our load.** We are overwhelmed, lonely, stressed, isolated, anxious or depressed. It may be something that no one knows about. No one sees the burden you carry. Or perhaps it's your roommate, or a classmate that you think has it all. **Under the veil or the mask there is a burden weighing them down.**

Recognizing our True Worth

- According to Tanya- ALL of Judaism's rituals and mitzvahs have an intrinsic purpose of **elevating the soul over the body.**
- Tanya, “The foundation and root of the entire Torah is to raise and exalt the soul over the body.”
- This means elevating how we see ourselves beyond our materialistic self, to teach us how to perceive life beyond the external trappings.
- This is a deeper understanding of why Hillel was able to say that the ENTIRE Torah is to love your fellow/ don't do to others what you wouldn't want done to you.
- Loving a fellow ultimately means learning to recognise the soul as their ultimate, constant worth within.
- It's recognising that no matter if you “dislike” the externalities or temperaments of the person, or even resent them right now or can only see their seeming “brokenness”- and you feel “inclined” not to help them- you are urged to:
 - 1. **Recognise your own burden within that is mirrored in theirs.**
 - 2. **Even more so, to recognise the infinite soul within you and them that is connected and worthy, no matter who they are.**
- As the Baal Shem Tov elaborates: “You shall surely help along with him” means that we should aid the material self with its “burden,” by training it to recognize that the soul is the vehicle for its own refinement and elevation.”
- Ie: Perhaps what the Tanya is saying is that if we ‘get off our own (high) horse’ and ‘dethrone’ the material self from its natural station as the seat of our identity and the prime motivator of everything we do, then we can begin to recognise and actualise the spiritual essence within ourselves and within every person.” (Based on the Rebbe, adapted by Yanky Tauber via menaingfullife.com)
- In this sense, **we can recognise that we are all so much more than our struggles.**
- **Sometimes it just takes a helping hand to help someone unload a burden to allow them to see who they really are, to recognise their own resources and worth and take a step towards healing.**

Boundaries vs Doing Our Part

A further Question:

- What does “helping along with him mean?” Isn’t it too much of a burden to take on everyone else’s struggles and mental health issues? WHY should it be our responsibility? **Isn’t it better to create a boundary and not get involved?**
- The Talmud addresses this exact question:
- (Talmud, Bava Metzia 32a) “If the owner of the animal went and sat down and said to him, “Since the obligation rests upon you, if you desire to unload, unload,” he is exempt, because the verse says, “You shall surely help along with him.”
- The Talmud is clearly showing us: Sometimes, you can only help someone who wants to help themself.

Our Small Part

- **We cannot literally take on everyone’s burden around us alone. Everyone needs to take self-responsibility. Yet- If you notice someone buckling under their load, it's our responsibility to do our part.**
- **(Ethics of our Fathers 2:16) “It is not your obligation to complete the work, but neither are you free to desist from it.”**
- There is an empowering teaching from the famous Chassidic Master-R Mendel of Kotzk : “Just like Batya, the daughter of Pharaoh saw a child floating in a basket and stretched out her arm to reach it. Miraculously (rashi exodus 2:5) her arm stretched many feet and she succeeded in reaching it. She stretched her arm to do SOMETHING even though it seemed her action would be ineffective. Similarly, we must do our part, even if chances for success seem bleak, and ultimately G-d “stretches” our “arm tenfold and helps our efforts to bear fruit.”
- You can choose to add more here: At the end of Chapter 32 of Tanya the Alter Rebbe goes as far as to say, that even if one doesn’t succeed in helping their friend (in this case, to feel unburdened, feel safe etc, we still always have a mitzvah to simply LOVE our fellow, no matter the result/ success.)

Just ASK

- Mostly that can just mean to simply ASK.
 - Ask if they need some help unloading.
 - Ask what you can do to ease their load today.
 - Ask how they are and actually STAY for the response.
 - Encourage the person to connect to resources to help them. (You can plug in your school resources here if on campus.)
- **Ultimately, a person has to want to get help too, but you never know what your genuine concern, empathy or smile may have done to improve that person’s day or lighten their load in some way.**

Optional/Extra: Another Parsha dimension of our social responsibility from Rabbi Lord Jonathan Sacks Z"L:

- **This dimension of the Parsha further emphasizes our responsibility to those who feel isolated, oppressed, burdened and struggling.**
- (No one can say it like Rabbi Sacks, so here is selected phrases from his original words in *Covenant and Conversation* 5779):
- (In Mishpatim) one command in particular stands out, by virtue of its repetition (it appears twice in our *parsha*):
- Exodus 22:20: "Do not ill-treat a stranger or oppress him, for you were strangers in Egypt."
- Exodus 23:9 **Do not oppress a stranger; you yourselves know how it feels to be a stranger [literally, "you know the soul of a stranger"], because you were strangers in Egypt.**
- *Bava Metzia* 59b. According to Rabbi Eliezer, the Torah "warns against the wronging of a *ger* in thirty-six places; others say, in forty-six places."
- Moses makes it clear that this is the attribute of G-d Himself:
- [Deuteronomy 10:17–19](#). "For the L-rd your G-d is G-d of G-ds and L-rd of L-rds, the great G-d, mighty and awesome, who shows no partiality and accepts no bribes. He defends the cause of the fatherless and the widow, and loves the stranger, giving him food and clothing. And you are to love those who are strangers, for you yourselves were strangers in Egypt."
- The most profound commentary is that given by Nachmanides:
- Ramban, commentary to [Exodus 22:22](#). "Because I behold the tears of such who are oppressed and have no comforter...Likewise you shall not afflict the widow and the orphan for I will hear their cry, for all these people do not rely upon themselves but trust in Me...for you know what it feels like to be a stranger, because you were strangers in the land of Egypt. That is to say, you know that every stranger feels depressed, and is always sighing and crying, and his eyes are always directed towards G-d, therefore He will have mercy upon him even as He showed mercy to you [and likewise He has mercy on all who are oppressed]."
- Rabbi Sacks Z'L: "**To be a Jew is to be a stranger.** It is hard to avoid the conclusion that this was why Abraham was commanded to leave his land, home and father's house; why, long before Joseph was born, Abraham was already told that his descendants would be strangers in a land not their own; why Moses had to suffer personal exile before assuming leadership of the people; why the Israelites underwent persecution before inheriting their own land; and why the Torah is so insistent that this experience – the retelling of the story on Passover, along with the never-forgotten taste of the bread of affliction and the bitter herbs of slavery – should become a permanent part of their collective memory."

- A textual example: In the course of the Joseph story in Egypt, the Israelites were regarded as pariahs (the word "Hebrew"-(Ivri- "other") seems to have strong negative connotation.
- One verse in particular – when the brothers visit Joseph a second time – indicates the distaste with which they were regarded:
- Genesis 43:3: *"They served him [Joseph] by himself, the brothers by themselves, and the Egyptians who ate with him by themselves, because Egyptians could not eat with Hebrews, for that is detestable to Egyptians."*
- Rabbi Sacks concludes: "The Torah asks, why should you not hate the stranger? Because you once stood where he stands now. You know the heart of the stranger because you were once a stranger in the land of Egypt. If you are human, so is he. If he is less than human, so are you. You must fight the hatred in your heart as I once fought the greatest ruler and the strongest empire in the ancient world on your behalf. **I made you into the world's archetypal strangers so that you would fight for the rights of strangers – for your own and those of others, wherever they are, whoever they are,** whatever the colour of their skin or the nature of their culture, because though they are not in your image, says G-d, they are nonetheless in Mine. There is only one reply strong enough to answer the question: **Why should I not hate the stranger? Because the stranger is me."**
- **Conclusion: In relation to Mental Health inclusion, we are pleaded with to learn to reflect and mirror G-d Himself. More so, G-d asks us to find empathy within ourselves. As a Jew we can reach into our collective memory of feelings of isolation to understand others by virtue of our own struggles and experiences.**

Back to Esther

- Let's zoom back in to our heroine- Queen Esther- hiding her identity in the King's Palace. Her people become a target for persecution. If she faces the king when she has not been summoned, she can be put to death.
- **It is Mordechai who sees her burden, sees her struggling under her loading, and with words of empowerment, he builds her up to see her own worth, resources, power and faith.**
- **Ultimately this guides her to recognise her own profound ability to do her part to unburden the load of the Jewish people.**
- *Megillat Esther: Chapter 4:14 And Mordechai said to relay to Esther, "...who knows if it is not for just such a time that you reached this royal position."*
- *15 Esther said to relay to Mordechai:*
- *16 "Go and gather all the Jews who are in Shushan and fast ... Then I shall go to the king, though it is unlawful, and if I perish, I perish."*
- This echoes the powerful teaching above that **our simple recognition of another's struggle, our words of understanding or motivation, can literally transform and save lives.**

Conclusions:

Adding Joy in Adar:

- Returning to our original Question- how can add a little bit of joy this month, amidst the current darkness?
- Our Sages teach that the G-dly soul is in a natural state of connection and happiness. Psychological and physical burdens, and often it feels that life itself, become seemingly insurmountable barriers towards experiencing this.
- **This Adar, perhaps increasing joy for ourselves and others, is thinking about what ONE barrier we can help remove, one burden we can help unload, whether for ourselves or for someone else. What is one small burden I can help someone unload by being present? What is one small burden I can unload from myself by showing my self compassion and recognising my true worth?**

Ending of parsha:

- **Optional:**
- 1. The end of the portion returns chronologically to last week and speaks of the preparations of the Jewish people made before receiving the Torah at Mt. Sinai. The people of Israel proclaim, "We will do and we will hear all that G-d commands us." (24:7) From the Chassidic Masters: "The greatness of the people of Israel was not that they were prepared to "blindly" do G-d's bidding without understanding (in which case they would have said only "we will do"), but that they placed their doing before their understanding. G-d desires that we should do as well as "hear" and comprehend His will, so that we serve Him not only with our hands and feet, but also with our minds and hearts. But our doing should serve as the basis of our understanding, rather than the other way around."
- 2. At end - G-d promises that if we adheres to our responsibilities, when we enter the Land of Israel- **G-d "will bless your food and your drink, and will remove illness from your midst."**(23:25)

Concluding blessing/ L'chaim:

- **In the merit of our relentless desire to be present and care for our fellow no matter our limited understanding, may G-d completely "remove illness from our midst"** (Mishpatim 24:7) as He promises the Jewish people as they prepare to enter the land.
- **May we merit to truly feel the month of joy we are in and celebrate Purim together in person- celebrating the end of our uncertainty and isolation, and the transformation of this pandemic/catastrophe/ collective and personal pain- into joy, health, and peace of mind, body and soul for all.**